

Daily Content Intel

June 25, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, so most of the speed work I see with football and lacrosse athletes is straight-line sprinting, which is great, but the game is rarely a straight line. It's planting, cutting, reacting, and changing direction under pressure.

There's a randomized trial on young soccer players where one group added speed, agility, and quickness work three times a week for eight weeks, the footwork drills, the lateral shuffles, the ladder stuff, the reactive starts. The group that did the SAQ work significantly improved their long sprint speed and their change of direction compared to the group that trained as

usual.

Here's why that matters. Change of direction is its own skill. You're decelerating, you're reorienting, and you're reaccelerating, and your body learns that pattern by drilling that pattern. You have to train the cut to own the cut.

So Monday, I'd add two or three short blocks of multidirectional work to your warmup or your speed day. Lateral shuffles, crossover runs, quick footwork into a sprint, react to a call and go. Keep the reps short and crisp, full recovery, quality over grind.

Do that for eight weeks and you get harder to guard. Does that make sense?

Hook: Agility ladder work looks like warmup filler, and the research says it actually makes athletes faster.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, so most of the speed work I see with football and lacrosse athletes is straight-line sprinting, which is great, but the game is rarely a straight line. It's planting, cutting, reacting, and changing direction under pressure.

There's a randomized trial on young soccer players where one group added speed, agility, and quickness work three times a week for eight weeks, the footwork drills, the lateral shuffles, the ladder stuff, the reactive starts. The group that did the SAQ work significantly improved their long sprint speed and their change of direction compared to the group that trained as usual.

Here's why that matters. Change of direction is its own skill. You're decelerating, you're reorienting, and you're reaccelerating, and your body learns that pattern by drilling that pattern. You have to train the cut to own the cut.

So Monday, I'd add two or three short blocks of multidirectional work to your warmup or your speed day. Lateral shuffles, crossover

runs, quick footwork into a sprint, react to a call and go. Keep the reps short and crisp, full recovery, quality over grind.

Do that for eight weeks and you get harder to guard. Does that make sense?

On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 Cutting is a skill
- 0:10 SAQ = Speed, Agility, Quickness
- 0:22 RCT: SAQ 3x/week for 8 weeks
- 0:32 Result: faster long sprint + better change of direction
- 0:45 Decelerate → reorient → reaccelerate
- 0:58 Add 2-3 short multidirectional blocks
- 1:10 Train the cut to own the cut

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Straight-line speed gets you recruited.

Change of direction wins you reps.

Most of the speed training I see for football and lacrosse athletes is forward sprinting. Useful, but the game lives in the cut, the plant, and the reaction.

A randomized trial on young soccer players added speed, agility, and quickness work 3 times a week for 8 weeks. The SAQ group significantly improved long sprint speed and change of direction versus the group that trained as usual.

Change of direction is its own skill. You decelerate, reorient, and reaccelerate, and you only get good at it by drilling it. Add 2 to 3 short multidirectional blocks to your warmup or speed day: lateral shuffles, crossover runs, quick footwork into a sprint, react and go. Short reps, full recovery, clean quality.

Eight weeks of that and you get harder to guard.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT
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#footballtraining #lacrosse #speedtraining
#changeofdirection #agilitytraining
#athletedevelopment
#strengthandconditioning #youthsports
#returntosport #SAQ #speedandagility

#sportsperformance

Personalize this

- You program HS football and work a NoVA football plus club-lacrosse audience. What does your in-season versus offseason multidirectional work look like, and how do you fit SAQ blocks around practice load without frying their legs?
- Have you had an athlete who timed fast in a straight line but kept getting beaten on cuts? What did you change in their training, and what showed up on the field?
- Where does deceleration and change of direction live in your CROSS method, and how do you layer reactive agility back in for a return-to-sport athlete coming off a knee or ankle?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10936847/> | "SAQ training on sprint, change-of-direction speed, and agility in U-20 female football players"

- physiology | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10936847/> | "the players in the SAQ group significantly enhanced sprint speed over long distances and COD ability, compared to those in the control group"
- actionable | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10936847/> | "coaches and conditioning practitioners can implement a periodised SAQ conditioning over 8 weeks, which can enhance players' ability to sprint and perform multidirectional movements"

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10936847/>
- <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-026-46144-2>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. The keto versus carbs war is the wrong fight for an athlete.

There's a 2026 meta-analysis, 33 studies, trained endurance athletes, looking at low-carb and ketogenic diets. And the fat-burning numbers are wild, every single study that measured fat oxidation saw it go up, some by almost 200 percent. So yeah, keto makes you an elite fat-burner.

Here's the catch. Max aerobic capacity, your VO₂max, was preserved in about half the studies and improved in roughly 1 in 10. So it mostly didn't help anyone get faster. And your submaximal economy, how efficient you are at race pace, that's where it took the biggest hit.

Now think about football and lacrosse. Your sport is repeated sprints,

collisions, and high-intensity bursts, and that work runs on carbs. Starve the system that fuels your best efforts and you just end up tired and flat.

So here's my actual position. Fuel for the demand. Eat carbs around your hard training and your games, lean on fat for the easy aerobic days, and let your metabolism stay flexible enough to use both. Fuel the work you're actually asking your body to do.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Keto makes you an incredible fat-burner. Whether it makes you faster is a different story.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, hot take. The keto versus carbs war is the wrong fight for an athlete.

There's a 2026 meta-analysis, 33 studies, trained endurance athletes, looking at low-carb and ketogenic diets. And the

fat-burning numbers are wild, every single study that measured fat oxidation saw it go up, some by almost 200 percent. So yeah, keto makes you an elite fat-burner.

Here's the catch. Max aerobic capacity, your VO2max, was preserved in about half the studies and improved in roughly 1 in 10. So it mostly didn't help anyone get faster. And your submaximal economy, how efficient you are at race pace, that's where it took the biggest hit.

Now think about football and lacrosse. Your sport is repeated sprints, collisions, and high-intensity bursts, and that work runs on carbs. Starve the system that fuels your best efforts and you just end up tired and flat.

So here's my actual position. Fuel for the demand. Eat carbs around your hard training and your games, lean on fat for the easy aerobic days, and let your metabolism stay flexible enough to use both. Fuel the work you're actually asking your body to do.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 Keto makes you a great fat-burner
- 0:10 2026 meta-analysis · 33 studies
- 0:20 Fat oxidation up to +200%
- 0:32 VO2max improved in ~1 of 10 studies
- 0:42 Economy at game pace took the biggest hit
- 0:55 Team sport runs on carbs
- 1:08 Fuel for the demand

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Keto will turn you into an elite fat-burner. Whether it makes you a better athlete is a different question.

A 2026 meta-analysis pooled 33 studies on low-carb and ketogenic diets in trained athletes. Every study that measured fat oxidation saw it climb, some by nearly 200%. Impressive.

The performance side is quieter. VO2max was preserved in about half the studies and improved in roughly 1 in 10. Running economy at submaximal pace, how efficient you feel at game speed, took the biggest hit.

Football and lacrosse are repeated sprints, collisions, and high-intensity bursts. That work is carb-powered. Starve that system and you show up flat for the efforts that decide games.

Fuel for the demand. Carbs around hard training and games, fat for the easy aerobic days, a metabolism flexible enough to use both. Fuel the work you're actually asking your body to do.

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#fuelforperformance #sportsnutrition
#footballtraining #lacrosse #ketodiet
#carbohydrates #athletenutrition
#metabolicflexibility
#strengthandconditioning #youthsports
#sportsperformance #athletedevelopment

Personalize this

- You work a NoVA football and club-lacrosse audience. What does in-season fueling actually look like for your athletes around back-to-back games

or two-a-days, and where do you most often see kids under-eating carbs?

- Have you had an athlete go very low-carb and watch their high-intensity output drop off? What did you change, and how fast did they bounce back once carbs came back around training?
- Mike T. Nelson's metabolic-flexibility framing is to train the metabolism to use both fuels at the right time. How does that fit your CROSS method and how you coach fueling for return-to-sport athletes rebuilding work capacity?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12986964/> | "Effects of Low-Carbohydrate and Ketogenic Diets on Aerobic Performance in Trained Athletes: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis"
- physiology | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12986964/> | "Maximal aerobic capacity (VO₂max) was preserved in 50.0% of studies, with 11.1% documenting improvements."

- actionable | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12986964/> | "Evidence supports periodized carbohydrate strategies balancing metabolic adaptation benefits from low-carbohydrate training phases with carbohydrate requirements during competition."

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12986964/>
- [https://jn.nutrition.org/article/S0022-3166\(26\)00091-X/fulltext](https://jn.nutrition.org/article/S0022-3166(26)00091-X/fulltext)

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Velocity-based training: stop at 20% velocity loss instead of grinding to failure (2026 Frontiers study) — hot-take potential.
- Blood flow restriction to accelerate return-to-sport (Olympic decathlete case report, 2025) — teaching Reel.
- Plyometric microdosing / cluster sets for jump, sprint, and COD in youth soccer (PMC12040276 meta-analysis) — hold to space out from 6/18 plyo angle.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest (2026-06-25): thin day. Dr. Mercola (brain fog, potassium vs salt for blood pressure) — general-population, not athlete-relevant, skipped. Mike T. Nelson "Met Flex Madness" — podcast on metabolic flexibility (train your metabolism to use fat AND carbs at the right time, fuel for the demand); usable, fed Draft B's framing.

- PubMed / PMC (S&C, athlete-biased):
SAQ + change-of-direction (2026
Scientific Reports meta-analysis on
adolescent/young-adult team-sport
athletes; 2024 U-20 football SAQ RCT on
PMC); plyometric → jump/sprint/COD
meta-analysis (PMC12040276, 2025) —
held as runner-up to avoid repeating last
week's plyo angle; velocity-based training
(2026 Frontiers study).
- Nutrition / fueling: 2026 low-carb &
ketogenic diets vs aerobic performance
meta-analysis (PMC12986964, 33
studies); "From Metabolism to Medals"
2026 carbohydrate fueling guidelines (J
Nutrition).
- Blood flow restriction (Olympic decathlete
RTS case report, 2025) — runner-up.
- Unreachable for verbatim extraction:
nature.com (auth redirect) and mdpi.com
(403) blocked WebFetch; used PMC
mirrors for verbatim screenshot targets
instead.